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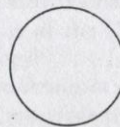
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PREVIOUS PAGE : Icon of St George of Bedia (detail)

ANCIENT CHRISTIANITY IN THE CAUCASUS

IBERICA CAUCASICA
Volume One



CURZON
 CAUCASUS WORLD

ST ANDREW IN SAMTSKHE — ARCHAEOLOGICAL PROOF?

Vakhtang Licheli

One of the historical regions of Georgia — Samtskhe — spreads across the territory to the south of the Meskheti Ridge: over the basins of the rivers Potskhovi, Kvabliani and the upper reaches of the river Mtkvari (Kiros). According to the old Georgian chronicle of the 11th century, *Kartlis Tskhovreba*, Samtskhe covered the territory from Tashis-Kari to the passes leading to the Black Sea. Since ancient times, Samtskhe, which derives its name from the Georgian tribe of the Meskhi (or Moskhi, according to ancient Greek sources),¹ was the region where not only different tribes but also different cultures came into contact; besides, the region had often been the setting of the opposition of diverse political forces.

For example, in the tenth century, one of the Georgian state formulations — the Tao-Klarjeti state — unified Georgia under the leadership of the reigning family of Bagrationi. From then on, Samtskhe was declared the property of the king and was governed by the Eristavis appointed by the king himself. The governors of Samtskhe (as well as of other parts of the country) made efforts to convert the region entrusted to them into one of hereditary ownership. This conflict was accompanied by a struggle for political primacy and was carried out by the Jaqelis of the Potskhovi Gorge, the Tsikhisjvarelis of the Odzrkhe-Abastumani Gorge, the Torelis of Tori, the Chorchanelis of the Kvabliani Gorge, and the Tmogveli governors of Tmogvi.

At first, the Jaqelis were dominant — in the second half of the 12th century, Borso Jaqeli was made the military leader (*spasalari*) of Samtskhe — but by the end of the 12th century, the Torelis took the upper hand. The Jaqelis, however, rose to the fore once more in the 13th century.

From the first half of the 13th century, Georgia had been occupied by the Mongols, and the occupation lasted a hundred years — a fact that delayed further development of the Georgian state as well as of Samtskhe. In 1266, the Jaqelis, supported by the Mongols, removed Samtskhe and Javakheti from power. At the beginning of the 14th century the king bestowed upon the Jaqelis the title of *atabagi* — the highest of that time. Henceforth the lands took the name of Samtskhe-Saatabago.

Samtskhe-Saatabago consisted of other southern provinces of Georgia besides Samtskhe and Javakheti. These were economically advanced regions where various types of agriculture and grain farming flourished (including wheat, oats, rye, millet). Market-gardening, viticulture, fruit-growing and other forms of cultivation were practiced. Cattle breeding (as well as sheep and swine) and handicrafts were also well developed.

It was in the 14th century that Beka and Aghbugha's Code was created in Samtskhe-Saatabago. By the end of the 16th century the whole region had come under the occupation of Turkey. Later, in 1829, under the Andrianopole Treaty, the territory was turned over to the Russian Empire.²

* * *

The arrival of St Andrew is closely connected with the religious and administrative centre of the ancient Samtskhe-Atskuri. The *Kartlis Tskhovreba* tells us that :

"Saint Apostle set off . . . and reached Atskuri, earlier called Sosangeti, which lies opposite Sakrisi. He stopped for a rest at a place that was a sanctuary of idols, now called the Old Church . . . The icon of the Holy Virgin lay in the fortress and great radiance could be seen there . . . A great many people filled the valley of Sakrisi . . .

There was a sanctuary of idols in the town where their evil gods were worshipped . . . But the grand icon of the All Holy Virgin of Atskveri lay at a little church . . ."

Having performed a number of miracles, and having persuaded the

population of Samtskhe of the great power of Christianity (which resulted in the governor of the region Samdzivari, along with the whole population, being baptized into Christianity), the Apostle Andrew proceeded on his journey, leaving the icon of the Holy Virgin in Atskuri.

The fortunes of the Atskuri Icon of the Virgin are closely interwoven with those of all of Samtskhe and Atskuri. During his eastern campaigns the seventh century Byzantine Emperor Heracles heard about "the miraculous icon that was created by the Virgin herself and given by her to St Andrew, who brought and laid the icon in a little chapel in Atskuri. The emperor came there to see and worship the icon. And he laid the foundations and started the building of a large church in Atskuri . . ."

In 1486, a Persian shah, Yaqub-Khan, invaded Samtskhe. After the seizure of Akhaltsikhe, he laid siege to Atskuri. The town pleaded for peace, and the shah relented. But later, having been defeated in Kartli, he came back and destroyed Atskuri in a rage and "led away" the icon of the Virgin. Atabag would not tolerate the theft, removed Matskvereli (i.e. the bishop of Atskuri) and, after "sending much silver," returned the icon to Atskuri Cathedral. Unfortunately, the king of Imereti, Bagrat III, then moved the icon to Tsikhisjvari in 1553, and later took the icon to Imereti (West Georgia).

Atskuri is often mentioned as a religious centre of Samtskhe in written sources. For example, according to the *Life of Grigol Khandzteli*, a bishopric cathedral already existed in the eighth-ninth centuries :

"Grigol . . . set off . . . and reached the outskirts of Kartli, and with the help of God . . . he met Ephrem the Younger, a youthful and worthy man, and in his dignity, he saw the immaculate nature of him who reached the man's maturity, and in his priesthood, he was the bishop of Atskuri, the maker of miracles . . ."

By the end of the 13th century, a strong earthquake destroyed Samtskhe — not a single building was left intact. Under the ruins of Atskuri Cathedral, the icon of the Virgin was miraculously saved — "the dome covered the icon."

As a result of the separatist activity of the Samtskhe Eristavis, at the beginning of the 16th century when Mzechabuk governed Samtskhe, the Meskheti (Samtskhe-Javakheti) Church declared its independence from the Catholicos of Mtskheta. The head of the Meskheti Church was now Matskvereli, i.e. Catholicos of Atskuri, and commenced the appointment of bishops. Mzechabuk endowed the Zarzma Monastery to the Cathedral of Atskuri. The cathedral owned vast tracts of land, and Matskvereli swiftly became one of the greatest feudal lords. By the end of the 16th century, when Southern Georgia was occupied by the Turks, Atskuri (bordering on Kartli, still an independent part of Georgia), became a frontier area and the main town of Sanjak.

* * *

Such are the main historical facts relating to the subject under scrutiny here. It is quite clear that there are practically no records concerning the "baptism of Samtskhe" by St Andrew except for the two brief notes concerning the event in the first century.

It is natural under the circumstances that the only means of proving the authenticity of the facts provided in the written source is through the remains of material culture exposed during archaeological excavations. But it should first be defined which of the records of the written sources are to be testified.

In our case, the testimony of the authenticity of the notes in the *Kartlis Tskhovreba* may be based on four initial criteria. These are :

1. The existence of the Temple of the Virgin, the building of which is connected with the icon of St Mary left in Atskuri by St Andrew.
2. The existence of the fortress from around the beginning of our era, also connected with the arrival of St Andrew in Samtskhe.
3. The existence of a pre-Christian settlement in Atskuri, including traces from the first century, i.e. of the period of the arrival of St Andrew in Samtskhe.

4. Traces of considerable influence of Greek traditions on the settlement, mentioned in the written source as 'Sosangeti', could be taken as proof of the existence of a temple to Apollo and Artemis there, and hence the significance of this town for the region could be considered indisputable, i.e. Sosangeti could be presented as an administrative and religious centre in the first century which determined the arrival of St Andrew in the town.

Before we present archaeological material of excavations in Atskuri between the years 1988-1995, the longstanding interest in this area should first receive comment. Countess Proskovja Uvarova, who visited and studied as many memorials in the Caucasus as she possibly could — Atskuri among them — wrote in 1888 that :

"Atskuri, once a well-known fortress town at the mouth of the Borjomi Gorge, is now an insignificant Tatar village,⁶ over which the ruins of a fortress may be seen at the top of a hill, and the ruins of a vast church at its foot. Even the ruins of this church are enough to testify to the importance of the place where it had been built."⁷

Niko Berdzenishvili pointed out that studying Atskuri was important not only for the region in particular but also for Georgia as a whole. He assumed that the sanctuary of Leukothea, mentioned by the Greek geographer Strabo (first century BC—first century AD),⁸ was built by Frix in the land of Moskh on this site. The sanctuary was robbed twice in the time of Strabo : first by Pharnak of Bosphorus, later by Mithridate of Pergamon.⁹ Unfortunately, no archaeological evidence supports the siting of the sanctuary of Leukothea at Atskuri. Nevertheless, Berdzenishvili's assumption about the first Christian church having been built on the place of a pagan sanctuary seems to be credible.¹⁰ Archaeological material from Atskuri presented additional discoveries between 1914 and 1932.¹¹ These include bronzes of different periods (later bronzes belonging to the Middle Ages).

Such was the data in existence before the start of archaeological studies of Atskuri-Sosangeti. Bearing in mind the aims of this

study, Atskuri cultural findings will be analysed according to the criteria mentioned above.

* * *

THE CATHEDRAL OF THE VIRGIN

On the right bank of the River Mtkvari at the foot of a small hill are still visible the remains of the once great church, which in size exceeded all similar constructions of this type in Georgia. Richly ornamented details, fragments of six major columns, a partly preserved conch, and, sadly, rather fragmentary remnants of frescoes (in the windows of the apse, also on the southern and northern walls) all clearly demonstrate that Atskuri Cathedral had in fact been one of the most important Christian centres in Georgia.

The architecture of the building is still to be studied, but has been preliminarily dated to the 11th-12th centuries. Evidently, the socio-historical and political importance of Atskuri Cathedral is equal to that of such monuments of Georgian architecture as Bagrat Church in Kutaisi (11th century), Sveti-Tskhoveli in Mtskheta (11th century), Alaverdi in Kakheti (11th century).

The dome of the cathedral is ruined, as well as the upper parts of the walls but the eastern face is relatively better preserved. The apse and its two eastern sides had projected, angular walls. The middle part of the apse to the base of the conch is completely destroyed, but inside, narrow pillars and half-columns with globe-shaped heads are preserved.

Decoration of the apse from the outside (part of the arch and windows) shows that this part had been built before the earthquake in the 13th century and was not ruined. In a photograph taken by Countess Uvarova in 1888, one can see the richly ornamented western wall that, as is evident from its decoration, was rebuilt after the earthquake, i.e. around the 13th-14th centuries.¹²

Of no less importance is the fact of the existence of a baptistery to the south of the three-nave Church of the Virgin of the early Middle Ages. It is an annexe to a monumental building, the function and the exact dating of which are not yet clear. It may

only be noted that the building had ceased its existence before the erection of the Cathedral (the excavations of 1988-89 and 1994-95). This is attested to by archaeological material (the waterpipe of the 11th-13th centuries was laid over the monumental building that had by that time lost its meaning) and the stratigraphic study of the monument (both of the excavated buildings are situated lower than the floor of the Cathedral of the Virgin).

Thus the information presented by the written source on the existence of Atskuri Cathedral is testified, i.e. it is objective.

ATSKURI FORTRESS

Atskuri Fortress, mentioned for the first time in connection with the arrival of St Andrew in Samtskhe, is a complex and interesting building. It is situated on a high rocky mass on the right bank of the river Kura, to the north of the cathedral.

The hill and the whole adjoining territory was connected with the fortress. Most of the fortress is now destroyed. The part of the citadel on the upper terrace is better preserved. The ancient strata of defences of the early feudal period adjoin to it in the form of a southern wall. The most recent are the southern and north-western walls (17th-18th centuries); situated on the lower terrace.¹³ On this side, a tunnel runs down from the fortress to the river.

A French traveller, Jan Chardin, who was in Georgia in 1672-73, wrote:

"On the right bank of the river Mtkvari, on the rock, a great fortress can be seen. From the south, the rock is surrounded by a double wall; a little town that resembles Akhaltsikhe is situated on the territory between the fortress and the mountain opposite it. The town is called Atskuri. It has a *sanjak*, an army, guards, customs."¹⁴

No archaeological excavations have yet been carried out on the fortress, but several construction periods can be traced in the ruins and defences. In my opinion, the most important are the trimmed blocks of greenish sandstone in the lower masonry of the southern wall. Their size as well as the character of their finish are notably

distinct from the granite stones with which the walls of the earlier Middle Ages and later periods were built. It is absolutely clear that during the erection of the walls of the citadel in the fourth-fifth centuries sandstone blocks of the earlier period, i.e. of the beginning of the New Era, were used. Moreover, sandstone blocks were preserved *in situ* and the wall of the earlier Middle Ages was in fact built over them.

Thus, this masonry could have corresponded fully to the period of St Andrew's arrival in Samtskhe and it could be considered as the preserved remainder of some pagan acropolis. Could all of the above be considered as a small sign of material proof of the existence of town settlements at the beginning of the New Era? Could the written source thus be considered attested? For, if the sandstone blocks originally belonged to defences (typically such blocks are also found in the defences of Vani and Bagineti of the second-first centuries BC),¹⁵ this could be considered as direct evidence of the economic strength of the town of Atskuri-Sosangeti. Building such constructions with other materials on an acropolis is hardly possible: our calculations for a similar defence wall carried out in Vani show that the erection of its adobe masonry portion (according to Sumero-Babylonian and Greek standards) demanded 8,330 workdays, cutting of the clay and baking bricks 4,166 workdays, expense of provisions: corn — 24,345 tons, meat — 6 tons, wages for workers — in excess of 228,000 drams.¹⁶

THE TOWN IN THE PAGAN PERIOD

The archaeological investigations that were begun in 1988 aimed at excavating and studying of the settlement of the pre-Christian period. Excavations have been carried out on the left bank of the River Mtkvari. Five trenches were dug at different strips of the assumed settlement. In each of these trenches cultural strata and burials of the seventh-first centuries BC were exposed. In trench 4, traces were revealed of a settlement of the first century AD, as well as burials of the earlier periods.

Stratigraphy of the monument is clearly presented in trench 3 (6m x 3m) which was dug in the north from the river bank at a distance of 300 metres, not far from the Borjomi-Akhaltzikhe

highroad. After removing a humus layer (at a thickness of 15-20 cm), the two following layers — yellowish loose (80 cm thick) and loam (4m thick) — containing no traces of material culture were revealed, i.e. as a result of accumulation of the upper rocks of the southern slopes of the Meskheti Ridge, a five metre-thick sterile layer of cobbles, was fixed only at the depth of 5.2m. Upon clearing the cobbles, a considerably deformed bronze bracelet and a fragment of a bronze finger-ring were discovered. These were roughly dated to the antique period. After removing a cobble obstruction, in the western corner of the trench, the two rows of parallel cobble masonry were cleared that represent a part of a round ground-plan building. Judging from the preserved fragment of the masonry (1 m wide by 60cm high by 3m long) which presents a foundation for wooden walls coated with clay, the diameter of the building is 7-9m (fifth century BC).

To the north of this building, another cobble obstruction was cleared. After its removal a foundation presents one row of masonry of larger cobbles, the masonry having a south-north orientation. its mean width is 0.5m, excavated length — 4.5m. It should be mentioned that this building also has a round ground plan, but it is much larger than the first. To the north of this larger building an altar of unusual structure is revealed: over the circle constructed of cobble (with a diameter of 1.25m) a cobble oval wall had been built, 1.15m high and 1.8-0.2m wide. Considering the fact that the stones bordering this small wall were specially picked out and preserved *in situ*, the altar, as we think, is presented in its original appearance. In the process of clearing the inner ground of the altar, traces of the ritual were exposed: burned bones, fragments of different types of ceramics, ashes. On the basis of studying ceramic material, the altar is dated to the fifth-fourth centuries BC.

Of particular interest is burial 3, excavated under the foundation of round building No. 1. The burial was supposedly enacted here after the building had been destroyed. The grave for the burial of a wealthy woman of 30-40 years old was bordered with cobbles. Items discovered in the grave included a black jug, golden temple rings, golden buttons, a silver torque, bronze and silver signet rings, glass and paste beads, bronze ear cleaners with sculptured portrayals of rams, bronze springs, schematic portrayals of a ram's head.

The grave site attributed to the beginning of the third century BC belongs to a ruling elite of the district of Samtskhe — as evidenced not only by articles of gold, but by the various signet rings which, as a rule, represent insignia.

Thus, taking into consideration these burials — the only wealthy burials of the time in Samtskhe — it could be assumed that since that period Atskuri-Sosangeti had been the administrative centre of Samtskhe. This assumption is supported also by analogous material from Colchis. Vani and Sairkhe, where notably wealthy burials have been excavated, were the administrative centres of *sceptuchia* in ancient times.

That Sosangeti was not only an important administrative centre but also the trading centre of the region is shown by the ceramic material classified in two groups: local and imported. We will not analyse local ceramics here, but mention only that alongside the forms of East Georgian and Colchian types, imitations of Greek forms (*louterion*) are also present.

Imported ceramics are represented by Greek ceramics of the sixth-second centuries BC (Ionian kylix, phials and kylices made in Athens and in the Greek towns of Asia Minor), as well as by Anatolian (fourth-second centuries BC) and Achaemenidian (fifth-fourth centuries BC) ceramics. Attention should be especially drawn to the presence of diverse amphorae of the Hellenistic period, more probably from South Pontic Greek towns. Such a concentration of imported Greek ceramics over such a long chronological stretch of time is unique for inner regions of Georgia and also for the whole of the Transcaucasus. This fact, no doubt, points to the special role held by this settlement.

In the partly studied segment of trench 4, on the eastern outskirts of the pagan town, over the cultural layer of the fifth-second centuries BC lie the exposed ruins of the building of the first century AD. These are supposedly medium-sized buildings with cobblestone foundations (0.25-0.35 cm wide). Unfortunately these buildings are not yet fully excavated and it is impossible to judge what kind of a ground plan they had or what was their function. However, the presented material makes it possible to rely on the written source which describes the existence of an important pagan temple on the place of the Christian town Atskuri.

The most important fact from the point of view of the opposition of two different religions — Christianity and paganism — is the confirmation of the strong Greek influence in that precise period (the middle of the first century AD). If the information in the *Kartlis Tskhovreba* concerning the sanctuary of Apollo and Artemis is based on true facts then, in testifying the trustworthiness of the written sources, one should attest either the complete absence of any kind of important Greek influence or its existence — for the temple of Apollo and Artemis itself shows at least the residing of a strongly Hellenized population, if not of an ethnic Greek element in Sosangeti. Not only the fact of the discovery of a Greek temple but also the confirmation of such a possibility is therefore important for solving this problem.

It is well known that religious beliefs are the strongest opposition to outside influences in the mentality of an ethos. It is the most conservative sphere of spiritual life. That is why any changes in this field could only result after continuous, strong influences. Such facts are well-established in the territory of Georgia, such as the discovery of the so-called Charon's obols in burials of the local population.

As we know, putting a coin into the mouth of a deceased is a particular Greek tradition, appearing in Georgia only after earlier visits by the Greeks. Moreover, this tradition is evident either in those places consistently inhabited by Greeks or in those points of contact with Greeks. Generally, these tend to be towns or larger settlements.

The burial of a warrior (Dedatos) in Vani serves as one such example. Vani, being an administrative centre of *sceptuchia* and later on also a religious centre (third-first centuries BC) had constant contact with the Greek world, a fact which is reflected not only in the existence of imported ceramics but also in the deep instillation of the elements of the Greek way of life.¹⁷ A burial site which is dated to the third quarter of the fourth century BC contained, among other inventory, a golden stater of Philip II of Macedonia (359-336 BC).¹⁸ Further inland, such facts are revealed on the territory of Mtskheta, the ancient capital of Iberia (Eastern

Georgia) : at the necropolis of Samtavro, in graves in pithoi from the first century BC, Arshakidian drams¹⁹ are found. These are also found in an ancient town on the site of modern Aghaiani.²⁰ The existence of a Greek ethnic element in Mtskheta is witnessed not only by written sources (among the most widely spread languages, Greek is also mentioned in the *Kartlis Tskhovreba*, but also by epigraphic²² and archaeological material.²³

We conclude that Charon's obols are the direct indication of either strong Greek influence or, more than that, of the existence of Greek ethnic elements.

Against this background, the discovery of Charon's obol — a silver coin of a Pontic king, Polemone II (49-63 AD) — in Sosangeti-Atskuri burial 4-95 (trench 4) is of particular significance. To the above may be added the following :

1. In the late Hellenistic period (the second-first centuries BC), not far away from Atskuri (15 km to the north east), near Bornigele, such a tradition was already in evidence.
2. Charon's obols were also already practised in the necropolis of Tsnisi, 10 km from Atskuri, in the fourth-third centuries BC.²⁵

Thus the above-mentioned facts in Atskuri are not coincidental : there is no doubt of Hellenized inhabitants living in this town. This, in its turn, is direct proof of the possibility of the existence of the temple of Apollo and Artemis — which implies that the written sources are reliable.

On the other hand, the possibility of the existence of such a temple supported with rich archaeological material points to the fact that Sosangeti was indeed the administrative and religious centre of the region, and this explains the arrival of St Andrew in this very town.

It should be especially emphasised that, according to the written sources, on his way to Atskuri, St Andrew stopped at the settlement of Benara where the statue of the pagan god Zaden was erected. As a result of excavations on Mount Zadena (Benara in the Adigeni region) on the top of a hill bordered with large monoliths,

a pedestal with a special quadrangle groove for fixing a large object was cleared.

* * *

We may conclude by saying that the analysis of the material components — the existence of the temple of the Virgin; the existence of the fortress at the beginning of our era, i.e. at the time of the arrival of the Apostle; the existence of a large settlement, a town of a pre-Christian period, including the first century AD which is the date of the baptizing of the population of Samtskhe by St Andrew; strong Greek influence which supports the theory of the importance of this town as a religious centre at the same time during the first century — which are mentioned in the story of St Andrew's arrival in Samtskhe-Sosangeti, gives enough ground for assuming authenticity of the information given in the written source. Accordingly, the possibility of the arrival of the Apostle Andrew to Samtskhe is wholly supported archaeologically.